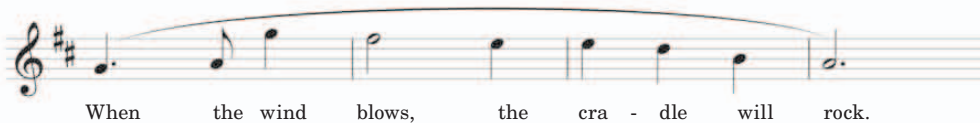


Phrasing and phrase marks

Phrases divide melodies into musical sentences. Similar to punctuation marks, they show where a musical thought stops and another one begins. Phrase marks indicate where performers may breathe, or musically regroup for a new idea.

Musical sentences

Musical phrase marks are long, gentle arches that put an entire musical thought under one umbrella. Generally, a phrase sounds relatively complete even when played out of context, especially if it ends on *do* or a tonic chord.



SEE ALSO

Types of phrases	96–97 >
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The phrase starts here

The phrase ends here

△ Phrase mark

The end of this rainbow-shaped symbol indicates that the performer may breathe, raise fingers, or lift the bow, ready to begin again.

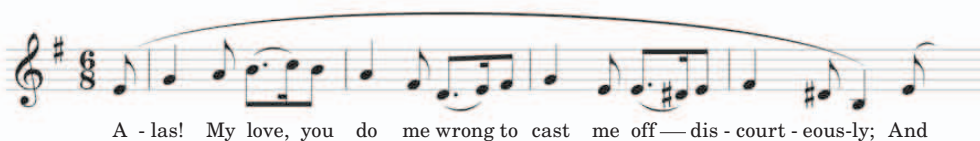
<△ Phrase marks in a tune

Sing this lyrical tune, “Rock-a-bye Baby,” and observe how the first phrase finishes at the end of the first complete thought.

Places to breathe

Musical phrase marks indicate where singers would naturally take a breath—at the end of an idea. The phrase endings here coincide with commas or periods in the text. Keyboard, wind, and string players observe the same breaks; this helps listeners organize the sounds.

Imagine if there were **no commas** and **no periods** in anything you ever read; it would be so **confusing**, and you would probably have a **hard time understanding** what the **author intended to say**.



<△ Phrase marks in a tune

Longer phrases sound more pleasing and musical than shorter ones, which sound choppy. In this extract from the English folk song “Greensleeves,” the phrase extends over the exclamation point and the comma contained in the text.